

A WORLD BANK STUDY



Getting the Right Teachers into the Right Schools

MANAGING INDIA'S TEACHER WORKFORCE

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Teachers in School

Roles and Responsibilities: Day-to-Day Management

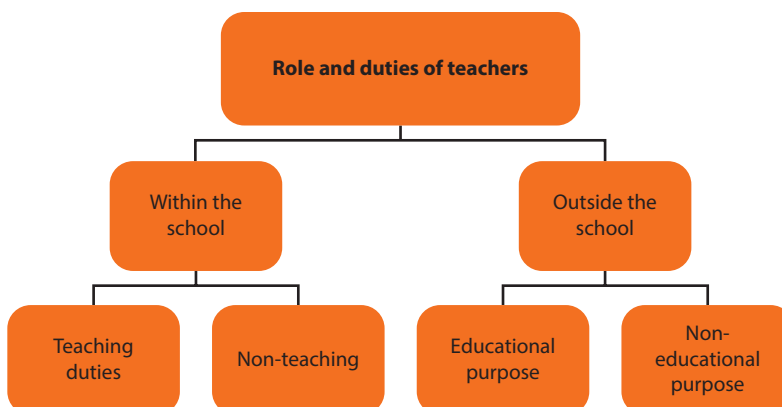
This chapter discusses three aspects of the working conditions of teachers in schools, which have a direct bearing on how teachers feel about their work. First, the chapter looks at the roles and responsibilities of teachers as prescribed and practiced, how teachers become aware of the same, and how teachers are given feedback and support. Second, the chapter examines the challenges faced by teachers in schools. Finally, the chapter investigates issues faced by school leaders and their relationship with teachers.

Roles and Responsibilities of Teachers

The terms “teacher” and “teaching” invoke a classroom full of students who are being taught. However, the role of a teacher, especially that of a government teacher, is far more diverse. According to section 24 of the Right to Education (RTE) Act, all teachers should perform the following duties:

- Maintain regularity and punctuality in attending school.
- Conduct and complete the curriculum.
- Complete the entire curriculum within a specified time.
- Assess the learning ability of each child and, accordingly, provide additional instructions, as required.
- Hold regular meetings with parents and guardians and apprise them of the regularity in attendance, ability to learn, progress made in learning, and any other relevant information about their child.
- Perform other such duties as may be prescribed.

Most state governments have incorporated the RTE provisions into their own rules and regulations and, therefore, these duties are applicable for all teachers in government elementary schools. However, translating these duties into practice in spirit is a challenge that is yet to be addressed fully in almost all the states. Figure 7.1 depicts the diversity of teacher roles as it plays out in practice in Karnataka.

Figure 7.1 Roles and Duties of Teachers: Karnataka

Sources: Centre for Budget and Policy Studies, Bangalore 2014 (<http://www.nuepa.org/New/completed%20reaserches.aspx>); Karnataka State Report.

Teaching comprises various facets, including planning and preparation, classroom activities, assessment, and reporting. In addition, the National Curriculum Framework (NCF) 2005 visualizes active engagement with parents as one of the important roles of a teacher. Almost all states assign these responsibilities to teachers, with emphasis on “maintaining results.” There is a spectrum of the degree of detail different states have gone into while assigning such responsibilities. At one extreme is Tamil Nadu, which has specified the daily and weekly schedule of government elementary school teachers in the state. Then there are states like Rajasthan, which have a broad definition of teacher roles. For example, the job charts specify the following duties for grade II teachers (source: State Reports):

1. Maintain the results of classes VIII and X in consonance with the overall results (more than minimum 30 percent).
2. Organize a minimum of two co-curricular activities each year.
3. Participate in a training, orientation, creative writing, or professional enhancement activity once a year.
4. Participate in school administration activities, class teacher, work-in-charge, examination-in-charge, subject-in-charge, and so forth, and take responsibility for a minimum of one activity.
5. Prepare question papers, evaluate answer books, conduct practical exams, and so forth.
6. Facilitate inspection by the District Institute of Educational Training lecturer once every three months.

Finally, there are states like Mizoram, where no job charts seem to exist. In the absence of a job chart, it is left to the teachers and officers to define the roles of

the teachers on a day-to-day basis. Naturally, this leads to a vague definition of the roles (source: State Report).

Karnataka, perhaps, has the most balanced and comprehensive definition of teacher roles. In a series of notifications published during 2014, teaching duties were defined as follows (source: State Reports):

1. Framing the weekly timetable for the class
2. Ensuring that all students have the relevant textbooks (provided by the government)
3. Preparing lesson plans as per the timetable
4. Explaining topics and chapters using simple teaching and learning materials
5. Maintaining student-related records (socioeconomic profile of students, parent-related information, attendance, and academic (Continuous and Comprehensive Evaluation (CCE)) records)
6. Providing remedial classes for slow learners
7. Conducting and assessing tests.

Non-Teaching Functions

The *non-teaching functions within schools* include providing administrative support, organizing events, managing midday meals, managing construction, collecting and maintaining data on students, facilitating visits of officials, and distributing uniforms, books, and so forth. Typically, these are functions of the headmaster, but, given that in most states support staff have not been appointed in government schools, it is natural that the headmasters turn to teachers. Some of these tasks are quite sensitive, as they involve managing large sums of money, supervising other workers, and maintaining multiple records.

Teachers are also involved in various *functions outside the school* that may be classified into educational and noneducational. Training programs; attachment with Cluster Resource Centers (CRCs), Block Resource Centers (BRCs), and the District Education Officer's (DEOs) office; curriculum development; marking board examination answer sheets; and so forth are some of the educational engagements of teachers outside the schools. At one level, these tasks augment the capacities of teachers and may lead to their growth. At the same time, these tasks are likely to divert teachers' attention from the pupils at their school.

Noneducational responsibilities outside school are perhaps the most talked about. Teachers have been involved in the census, elections, and disaster management, and continue to be. For some time, the diversity of such tasks had become quite alarming and teachers were being used for tasks such as migration surveys, livestock surveys, family planning targets, and immunization.

Teachers informed us (in discussions conducted in the nine states) that after RTE 2009, their nonteaching duties have been streamlined and clearly specified. However, we did not come across any government order or notification to this effect. In Tamil Nadu, the teachers informed us that in addition to elections and census-related duties, they also distribute textbooks and uniforms. These are

viewed as “educational/school-related tasks.” As these materials do not come in one go, this work carries on for several months. Equally, teachers in several states said that they have to go to the block office to collect the textbooks and uniforms.

In Mizoram, the teachers particularly mentioned the midday meal (MDM) program, and said that they receive little administrative support when they must go outside the school to purchase items or organize fuelwood.

In Jharkhand, since the RTE, apart from the mandated duties like the census, survey of out-of-school children, and elections, teachers are not assigned any other duties outside the school. However, this is not true for all the states. During one focus group discussion (FGD) with teachers in Odisha, they reported that:

Non-teaching duties (post-RTE) has reduced on paper, but not so on the ground. Work related to civil works and MDM are quite excessive... The Headmaster/Headmistress has the responsibility of procuring and maintaining bill vouchers in this regard. It is, of course, a regular practice that the HM cannot/does not alone do it and he/she involves other teachers also. Experience shows that MDM is quite a sensitive issue and there are many registers such as Cash Book, Daily Expenditure Record, Bill Vouchers, Purchase Register, Stock Register, *Janch* (Verification) Register to be maintained by them. The present per student budget allocation for MDM was Rs. 3.79 for primary and Rs. 5.65 for upper primary that have recently been increased to Rs. 4.03 and Rs. 6.04 excluding rice. This is insufficient to maintain prescribed quality of MDM. Moreover, the factors such as maintaining equation with the Self-Help Group/SMC, arranging firewood etc. are quite cumbersome affairs and this really puts the teachers on the back foot... when the supervising officials come their monitoring and supervision remain confined mostly to MDM and civil work. They verify bills, vouchers, record, quality etc. and do not bother/find time to monitor academic aspects of the school. (Odisha State Report)

The Karnataka State Report has compiled statistics from the Unified District Information System for Education to demonstrate this point, as shown in table 7.1.

In Madhya Pradesh, it was reported that a window has been kept open for utilizing the services of teachers for other purposes, albeit with the consent of the education department. At the field level, however, there are reports where

Table 7.1 Percentage of Teachers Involved in Non-Teaching Assignments in Elementary Schools in Karnataka, 2009–10 to 2012–13

<i>Teachers</i>	<i>2009–10</i>	<i>2010–11</i>	<i>2011–12</i>	<i>2012–13</i>
Number involved in non-teaching assignments	20,514	35,738	34,096	4,974
Total number	280,282	297,502	387,130	306,117
Percentage involved in non-teaching assignments	7.32	12.01	8.81	1.62

Source: Compiled from Unified District Information System for Education data for 2009–10, 2010–11, 2011–12, and 2012–13.

teachers continue to be deployed beyond the tasks stipulated in the RTE. Such deployment is sometimes at the behest of teachers as well, as this allows them to be located at their preferred location (Madhya Pradesh State Report).

According to a recent study on teachers' time-on-task, conducted by the World Bank in three states of India—Andhra Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, and Uttar Pradesh—actual teaching time is only 81 to 87 percent of 223 to 231 school-calendar days (Sankar and Linden 2014). The balance of the time is spent on various non-teaching and non-school tasks. The study goes a step further and explores whether teaching-time is spent on student-centric activities or otherwise, through classroom observations. Of all the teaching-time observed, only 24 percent was deemed to be student-centric. This finding is not surprising for anyone who has observed government schools in India, where teachers and the education system have not internalized NCF 2005 in spirit.

In addition, the diversity of roles—*learning facilitator versus school administrator versus civil servant versus community mobilizer*—creates a *suboptimal identity* where the teacher experiences conflict between the different roles that he/she is expected to play. Naturally, this has a negative impact on teaching. It also affects accountability for the learning outcomes of students.

Support, Feedback, or Inspection?

The *inspection, feedback, and support systems* in most states were found to be dysfunctional. Teachers and administrators said that the number of schools has expanded rapidly over the past two decades. For example, in Uttar Pradesh, the number of schools has more than doubled since 2000; however, the inspection and support system has not grown proportionately. Although there are no hard data on the ratio of administrators to teachers, in several states, the District and Block Education Officers we interviewed mentioned this as a serious issue. For example, in Lunglei District of Mizoram, the officers said that the staffing patterns of the district and block offices have not changed in the past 20 years, although the number of teachers has increased and so has the range of administrative duties that must be performed. The attempt made through the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan, to create CRCs and Block Resource Centers has not worked. This was because appropriate staff could not be placed at these centers, or the short-sightedness of senior officers led to loading the centers with administrative work. Consequently, many schools are never visited (table 7.2). Only a few schools are visited regularly; invariably these are easily accessible “model” schools of some sort. As table 7.2 shows, 49 percent of schools across the country were not inspected at all in 2011–12, and 32 percent were not visited by CRCs.

Even the schools visited by the officers or CRCs are not provided feedback or given academic inputs. Most of the time is consumed in completing administrative formalities or, worse, fault-finding. This situation has been persisting for years and the government has made limited efforts to address it. This unintentional *laissez-faire* kind of autonomy given to teachers by the government not only

Table 7.2 Schools Visited by CRC and Inspected, 2011–12

State	Percentage of schools visited by	
	CRC coordinators	Percentage of schools inspected
Jharkhand	79	45
Karnataka	96	44
Madhya Pradesh	71	54
Mizoram	90	51
Odisha	78	42
Punjab	32	28
Rajasthan	54	61
Tamil Nadu	86	67
Uttar Pradesh	52	40
All India	68	51

Source: Elementary Education in India, District Information System for Education Analytical Tables 2012–13.

Note: CRC = Cluster Resource Center.

contributes to making the schools ineffective, it also makes it convenient to place the blame on the teacher as and when some issue comes to light. Equally, teachers find it easy to deflect the onus onto the system or administration.

Although some states mentioned “maintaining results” as one of the teachers’ responsibilities (for example, Tamil Nadu and Rajasthan), even when that is the case, the system places very *low expectations* on the teachers. If teachers can show that all the chapters given in the syllabus for the year have been “taught,” that is considered sufficient toward completion of their primary responsibilities. The teacher is allowed to explain poor learning and development of the student by citing various constraints, the biggest being the students and their backgrounds. No value is given to commitment and innovation. Although autonomy is conceptualized in the policy documents as an important element of professionalism, teachers rarely express the need for or consider that they lack autonomy.

Accountability

A related issue is the *lack of a sense of accountability* among teachers. Teacher absenteeism is a fairly common complaint of the government and community against teachers. This has been confirmed by research as well, namely, Kingdon and Muzzammil (2008), PROBE (1999, 2011), Dreze and Gazdar (1996), and Sharma and Ramachandran (2009). The Ministry of Human Resource Development (MHRD) commissioned a study on students’ and teachers’ attendance in primary and upper schools across the major states of the country (Government of India, MHRD, and SSA 2009). The study found that the average attendance of primary and upper primary teachers in 2006–07 was 81.7 percent and 80.5 percent, respectively. The attendance system of most states is weak, and the states do not have data on teachers’ attendance. Lack of

data also means that little action can be taken; even where data are made available through independent surveys and studies, there is serious lack of administrative and political will to address this issue.

Another alarming problem that was reported by two states in the study (Uttar Pradesh and Mizoram) is “proxy teachers,” whereby a teacher appointed by the government illegally “appoints” another person to work in her/his place for some consideration. The teacher uses this opportunity to take up another occupation or for some personal reasons, like house construction. Proxy teachers are more common in remote and rural areas, but this practice is also found in urban areas despite the proximity of government offices and officials. The extent of the practice of proxy teachers could not be determined during the preparation of this study, but it was openly discussed during FGDs.

Such practices of teachers are possible because of the *absence of effective monitoring and low probability of disciplinary action*. Teachers find a way to get around whatever limited monitoring is done. All state governments have provisions for disciplinary action, but it becomes very difficult to indict a teacher and take any serious action. A different interpretation of rules, pressure from teachers’ unions, humanitarian reasons, and so forth are all invoked when a situation of dereliction of duty or misconduct comes to light. The officer or committee considering the case tends to consider the political affiliations of the teacher, status of vacancies in the school, and so forth while taking the decision. Almost all officers at the district and block levels who were interviewed during the study cited such instances, on the condition of anonymity. As discussed in chapter 5, on teacher deployment, the provision of transfer for disciplinary action is rarely invoked. More often than not, the teacher is able to get away. Every such instance further encourages teachers to be errant. At the same time, it was also reported during FGDs with teachers and teachers’ unions that *officers could misuse their powers* to harass certain teachers. Some cases were reported in Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan, although most such cases do not come to public notice, as the teachers are afraid to rake the issue further. This is one area where it is difficult to find “hard evidence.”

Induction and Orientation

Teachers are expected to learn their roles and responsibilities on the job, as *induction or orientation programs* are not a regular feature in any of the states. Although all the positions seem to have a “probationary” period of two years, after which the teacher is to be confirmed, in practice, this has no relevance. The officials and the teachers are unable to state any difference between what happens or is expected from the teacher during the probationary period and otherwise. Madhya Pradesh has taken the idea of probation to another level, by converting the initial three years of service into contractual appointment. By doing this, the state has kept open the option of taking severe action against teachers, which could act as a deterrent for otherwise errant teachers and force them to focus on their responsibilities. The study could not obtain adequate evidence to explore this issue further.

Challenges Faced in Discharging Roles and Responsibilities

Responsibilities without Capacity Building and Adequate Support

Typically, the system engages with an issue early in the launch of the new intervention and then expects the teachers to take it forward regardless of whether they have been adequately empowered to do so. The implementation of continuous and comprehensive evaluation (CCE) is a clear example of this. In most states, CCE processes have been spelled out only partially and teachers often complain about the inadequate orientation and capacity building on the issue. Another interesting issue that came to light in Mizoram was that of the conversion of a government school from Mizo language to English medium following demand from the community. To the credit of the state government, it has instituted a system of screening where the State Council of Educational Research and Training assesses the English capabilities of the teachers of the applicant school and recommends whether the school should be converted. Notwithstanding the subversion of the screening process that was reported in some cases, the teachers of the converted school are expected to teach the entire syllabus of all the subjects in English, with no capacity building or support from any quarter.

Lack of Infrastructure and Teaching Aids

The status of school infrastructure in India has improved significantly, including in states that have started quite late. Yet, when measured against what would be desirable, a lot more needs to be done.

As table 7.3 demonstrates, many schools lack basic facilities like electricity, libraries, and playgrounds. Despite the emphasis ostensibly placed on information and communications technology, many schools do not have computers, even in the southern states like Karnataka and Tamil Nadu. A similar situation prevails in secondary schools, as discussed in chapter 2. Teachers in such schools must surmount these challenges while attempting to help young children learn and grow.

Table 7.3 Lack of Infrastructure Facilities, 2012–13

Facilities lacking in schools	Percentage of schools in states								
	JH	KN	MP	MZ	OD	PJ	RJ	TN	UP
Drinking water facilities	10	5	5	11	6	1	7	2	3
Girls' toilets	17	1	8	3	32	5	3	5	3
Boys' toilets	40	4	28	76	79	21	23	38	5
Electricity connection	89	4	77	51	77	1	52	4	62
Computers	92	72	88	73	91	50	78	47	90
Libraries	23	4	40	64	24	14	43	5	27
Playgrounds	69	38	44	51	71	19	52	25	27

Source: Drawn from Elementary Education in India, District Information System for Education Analytical Tables 2012–13.

Note: JH = Jharkhand; KA = Karnataka; MP = Madhya Pradesh; MZ = Mizoram; OR = Odisha; PB = Punjab; RJ = Rajasthan; TN = Tamil Nadu; UP = Uttar Pradesh.

It was observed and reported during FGDs that working spaces and furniture for teachers inside or outside the class are virtually nonexistent. There is no monitoring mechanism for such indicators and the District Information System for Education does not capture the availability of furniture and other teacher-specific facilities. Teachers who are posted in remote areas or where the habitations are very small often struggle to find a decent place to stay in such locations and are, consequently, forced to undertake long and arduous journeys. Given that many schools are located in rural areas, which lack basic as well as aspirational amenities, teachers feel frustrated about living and managing their families in such areas.

Teacher Vacancies

Teacher vacancies continue to plague the system, putting undue pressure and responsibilities on the teachers. Although state governments have been giving a lot of attention to recruitment in the past few years, motivated by the RTE, and state-level pupil-teacher ratios have improved substantially, a school-level analysis reveals that the problem is yet to be solved. This situation is discussed at length in chapter 2 of this report. The creation of new posts and recruitment are long and cumbersome processes influenced greatly by the willingness of the leaders of the state and the financial situation of the state government (discussed in chapter 3). Further, state governments find it difficult to rationalize teachers across districts and regions (discussed in chapter 4). It is common to find stark differences in the pupil-teacher ratios between urban and rural schools, since most teachers wish to be located in urban areas. As a result, teachers in deficit schools are forced to take on the responsibilities of the vacant positions. Although many teachers reportedly make spirited and praiseworthy efforts, these are likely to be suboptimal.

Multi-Grade Teaching¹

Primary school teachers often find themselves in a multi-grade situation, due to the lack of adequate teachers, an inadequate number of students in different grades, or inadequate classrooms in the school. As noted in chapter 2, approximately 42 percent of government elementary schools have only one or two teachers for the elementary grades. However, the teachers are not equipped to conduct multi-grade teaching effectively, despite clear policy directives at the national level. NCF 2005 suggests that teachers must undertake much more careful class and lesson planning when working in such scenarios. However, the entire teacher education process still treats the multi-grade situation as an anomaly. A research monograph by Blum and Diwan (2007) cites a teacher educator from Delhi as stating:

Multi-grade has a really negative reputation in India. In many places, both urban and rural, that I have visited, schools have big classes of 80 or more students in each grade. The teachers receive some discussion about how to manage multi-grade, but it is really theoretical and it doesn't address all the different situations that teachers may face in their postings...

The same monograph also cites a leading National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT) policy maker:

There is a general confusion about multi-grade in India. Is it a quality improvement measure—in which case you need skilled teachers working in small schools—or is it just an attempt to make the best of the bad situation, which many schools are currently in?

Therefore, it is not surprising to find that most teachers see multi-grade teaching as an impediment, which further complicates the issue. A few state governments—Karnataka and Tamil Nadu (through ABL) and Rajasthan (through Lehar Programme)—have taken proactive measures to support teachers in multi-grade situations. In general, however, teachers do not see this positively.

Continuous Comprehensive Evaluation

CCE has emerged as a big challenge for teachers and the education system alike. Teachers in the nine states talked about the bane of CCE. Notwithstanding that several states have conducted orientation and training programs for teachers on CCE, teachers and administrators opined that, given the existing pedagogic practices in India, the concepts of “comprehensiveness” and “continuity” in evaluation are difficult to comprehend. Consequently, the effort to transplant CCE into the traditional pattern of education has not met with success—except in pilot projects where the government, nongovernmental organization, or United Nations Children’s Fund partners have worked with teachers to develop the formats for CCE.

The teachers see CCE as something that has increased their workload significantly in terms of checking of examination papers and assignments and maintaining different records pertaining to students. There is a strong feeling among teachers that the abolition of examinations (in elementary education) and their replacement by CCE has resulted in poor student and teacher performance. This idea is contested by government officials, especially MHRD and its academic counterpart, NCERT. As so far there has been no study or evaluation of the implementation of the CCE system in India, it is premature to make any definitive statement on CCE.

Mismatch between Curriculum and Students’ Abilities

As has been widely reported, teachers are often faced with the situation where the students are unable to engage with the curriculum prescribed for a certain grade (World Bank 2014). This happens because the students lack the prior knowledge or experience that has been assumed by the curriculum formulators. Often, basic language and numeracy skills are missing in upper primary classes. In such a situation, teachers, quite naturally, blame the students and their background, the teachers of previous classes, and the education system, which has allowed students to move up the grades without acquiring the necessary skills. The problem is further exacerbated for students who are absent for long periods due to seasonal migration or health reasons. Ten years of the Annual Status of

Education Report Survey (2005–14) have repeatedly pointed out that over 50 percent of children in class V are not able to negotiate a class II text for reading or simple arithmetic (ASER 2005–2014). A recent study commissioned by MHRD, on inclusion and exclusion of children in schools and classrooms, captured the prevalent attitudes of teachers toward children from disadvantaged and marginalized social groups (Ramachandran, Naorem, and State Research Teams 2012).

Although it may be argued that teachers should expect to encounter such situations and be able to ensure student learning, this is obviously not a happy situation for a teacher. The concepts of bridge courses or remedial teaching exist in the system to address such problems; however, these have not proven to be effective. Teacher development processes do not address this issue. In this unfortunate situation, it is the students who often bear the brunt of the frustration of the teacher, because dissatisfied teachers are not good teachers.

Single-Teacher Schools

Single-teacher schools continue to be present in the system. This is especially true for remote, rural areas, as most teachers do not want to be posted in such areas. In such schools, teachers and students struggle to meet the multiple responsibilities of running the schools. Teachers must teach multiple grades simultaneously without adequate empowerment for the same. Every time the teacher is called for any responsibility outside the school, the school practically shuts down for the day/s. Making up for lost time is very difficult in such schools.

Midday Meals

Despite RTE provisions and subsequent notifications by the state government as well as an order from the Supreme Court on not giving teachers the responsibility of managing the midday meal, headmasters and teachers continue to be given this responsibility. This involves multiple challenges: ensuring rations are available on time and there is a functional cooking space available on a daily basis, managing the cooking staff, ensuring hygiene, ensuring all students receive at least the stipulated quantity, maintaining records, managing the funds flow situation, facilitating audits, and so on. Naturally, this takes significant time and energy away from teaching functions. It is also a sensitive responsibility, as demonstrated by some recent unfortunate incidents, like the Chhapra, Bihar, school meal poisoning on July 16, 2013; Bangalore, Karnataka on September 21, 2014; and Naiveli, Tamil Nadu, on July 18, 2013. This adds to the frustration that many teachers undergo.

Some states have reported good practices in this area, where self-help groups, formed under various departments, have been given the responsibility to provide the meals. This has eased the pressure on the headmasters and teachers.

Construction

Construction is another area in which teachers must struggle. It is quite common to find ongoing construction activities in the schools for expanding or repairing

the infrastructure. These activities must be supervised and managed by the headmaster and teachers. Like midday meals, this too is a sensitive issue where the teachers have to handle materials, money, construction workers, and records.

Implications of the RTE Provisions

Most teachers have yet to come to terms with several provisions stipulated by the RTE, like “no detention” and “no corporal punishment.” Teachers in the nine states said that such provisions have impinged on their professional rights and have made their tasks more difficult. Although teachers have cut down on corporal punishment, it is more out of compulsion than any real belief in the concept. Teachers and senior officials critiqued the no-detention policy; they said that this takes away the imperative of students to study. Although teachers recognize the principle behind the concept, they continue to feel the need for the possibility of retaining a student in a class if her/his learning level is inappropriate. The teachers have not been empowered to see these clauses in the light of the larger transformation that is being attempted through the RTE.

Management of School Management Committees

Various instruments and institutional forms have been used to facilitate the involvement of parents and communities around schools and their functioning, with the aim to build ownership as well as strengthen school accountability. The RTE has put a legal stamp on this issue with the provision that each school has a School Management Committee (SMC), with the mandate to manage all aspects of the school. The RTE has also specified that parents of children studying in a given school will form at least 75 percent of the SMC. The school system is coming to terms with this shift in power from the headmasters and officials to the parents and community. A recent National University of Educational Planning and Administration study (Singh 2011), which explored the status of school-level management committees in 14 states, reported that the headmasters continue to direct and control the committees. However, during discussions with teachers and headmasters, it emerged that in some places, the community has started asserting itself in civil works and school functioning.

During discussions conducted for this study, some teachers also talked about interference and harassment at the hands of SMC members. Although we do not have hard evidence to back this claim, and because the research tools did not specifically explore this issue, it is difficult to make any general statement on the relationship between teachers and the community. Looking at this objectively, not all of what is reported as interference would be undesirable. That was the whole reason such provisions were introduced in the first place. What needs to be done, however, is to build the capacities of teachers and headmasters to engage with SMCs and communities in a meaningful way, academically and administratively, and build the capacity of SMCs to contribute effectively (Dundar et al. 2014). School development planning presents an opportunity where the teachers and the community could be brought together effectively.

Roles of Contract/Para Teachers

Many contract/para teachers have been introduced in the education system over the past two decades. In several states, they are underqualified and low-paid, with their primary responsibility being to support regular teachers or undertake specific tasks. The introduction of contract/para teachers has allowed governments to bolster teacher strength without having to wait for augmenting teacher education capabilities, at a much lower cost. Such was the attractiveness of this mechanism that slowly the same state governments reduced regular appointments and started recruiting more and more contract/para teachers. Since contract/para teachers were contractual and, therefore, less prone to protest (in theory), the responsibilities of the non-regular teachers were enhanced by the headmasters and officials much beyond their initial brief. It came to a pass where contract/para teachers were performing the same duties as regular teachers, with much less pay. This led contract/para teachers to organize themselves and seek better salaries and regular status, which has been successful in many states. The presence of underqualified persons as teachers confused regular teachers and the society, and convoluted teacher management norms.

Roles and Challenges of School Leaders

Teachers look to school leaders for direction on the routine functions of the school, and to school leadership as an important growth avenue. However, the policy and practice of school leadership leaves a lot to be desired on both counts. Generally, school leadership is more defined at secondary schools than at elementary schools; primary schools are the worst off. In the states covered by the study, only Tamil Nadu seems to have empowered the institution of school leadership reasonably. Some of the key aspects of school leadership that came to light during the study are described in the following subsections.

Large Number of Vacancies

Without exception, all the states in the study have significant numbers of vacancies for the positions of headmasters and head teachers. As table 7.4 shows, Rajasthan has the least number of vacancies at the primary and upper primary levels. The maximum number of vacancies are in states like Jharkhand, Karnataka, and Madhya Pradesh. These vacancies have been computed only for schools that have a minimum enrollment of 150 for primary and 100 for upper primary.² If schools with lower enrollments are included, the vacancy percentage is likely to be even worse.

Such high levels of vacancies clearly indicate that governments have not taken this position seriously. A senior teacher is usually given the charge of a school and this arrangement continues for years. Sometimes, such vacancies arise due to inadequate feeder cadre, but many times, it can be attributed to administrative neglect and apathy. Often, positions are not created, recruitments and promotions are not done on time, and minor issues of seniority are allowed to escalate

Table 7.4 Vacancies in Headmaster and Head Teacher Positions

State	Vacancies in headmaster and head teacher positions in elementary schools (%)	
	Primary enrollment > 150	Upper primary enrollment > 100
Jharkhand	82	81
Karnataka	80	50
Madhya Pradesh	70	56
Mizoram	49	26
Odisha	67	71
Punjab	51	56
Rajasthan	16	20
Tamil Nadu	28	50
Uttar Pradesh	48	27
All India	45	46

Source: Drawn from Elementary Education in India, District Information System for Education Analytical Tables 2012–13.

into court cases that linger for years. In schools that do not have a regular full-time headmaster, not much can be expected from the leadership institution.

Limited Powers

In schools where there is a headmaster, the individual is constrained by the limited powers devolved to her/him. School leaders are delegated certain powers, such as granting leave, assigning responsibilities to teachers, and so forth. School leaders have few financial powers.

Inadequate Incentives, No Separate Cadre

Several instances were reported from states like Mizoram and Uttar Pradesh where eligible teachers preferred not to be promoted to the position of headmaster. Such teachers feel that the incentives, if any, were too little for the large additional responsibilities and workload of a headmaster. Most states do not have a separate cadre for headmasters, at least at the elementary level. Apart from the salary and other service conditions that a cadre usually defines and enhances, it also helps in creating a distinct identity that is essential for performing the duties effectively. At the same time, it could also be argued that having separate cadres has its problems, since school leaders should have had some teaching experience as well.

A recent study in Rajasthan reveals that women teachers were hesitant to take on the function of headmistress or head teacher, as that involved many hours of administrative work, financial responsibilities, political pressures, and related problems of dealing with men at different levels of society. And there is an unwritten practice in Rajasthan of not posting women as headmistresses in co-educational schools (Jandhyala and ERU Research Team 2014). This trend has imposed severe restrictions on the professional growth of women teachers and aggravated the overall shortage of teachers willing to assume additional administrative responsibilities.

Expanded Managerial Roles

Maintaining the student, financial, and administrative records of the school; periodic and nonperiodic reporting; and liaising with their nodal department are some of the tasks that headmasters have always carried out. For the past decade and a half, activities like midday meals and construction of buildings have emerged as major time-consuming activities for headmasters. All of this obviously leaves little time for academic support and supervision. This problem is further compounded because most primary and elementary schools do not have administrative, accounting, or support staff. This issue was reported by several states, including Karnataka, Mizoram, Jharkhand, and Rajasthan.

Neglected Academic Role of School Leaders

Apart from the time constraint, the system does not really expect the headmasters to play an academic role. If the headmaster can maintain records, submit reports, and provide utilization certificates, the system deems him or her to be an efficient headmaster. Real accountability for students' learning is not enforced on the headmaster. Tamil Nadu and Rajasthan appear to be the exceptions in this case. In Rajasthan, a few headmasters were reportedly suspended because of the poor results of their schools.

Inadequate Investments in Building Capacities

Karnataka (Azim Premji Foundation supported Educational Leadership and Management program), Tamil Nadu (UK-India Education and Research Initiative for secondary school teachers and headmasters), and the Central Square Foundation-supported **India School Leadership Institute reported new initiatives to build the capacities of school leaders**. In addition, in both these states, teachers receive paid leave to acquire higher qualifications. A certain percentage of headmaster positions is set aside for teachers who have upgraded their qualifications (see chapter 8 on professional growth). In other states, some capacity-building initiatives have been reported from time to time, but, in general, headmasters are left to learn the ropes on their own. Most states do not even conduct an orientation or induction program for headmasters on their roles and the expectations from them.

Summing Up

The Indian reality is quite unique—teachers are expected to play a diverse role in the school, in the classroom, and in the community. Although the RTE has certainly emphasized the teaching function of teachers, a lot more needs to be done to define the roles and responsibilities of teachers and insulate them from tasks that divert them from their primary responsibility of teaching. Support and supervision are effectively two sides of the same coin. But the hard reality is that teachers in Indian schools are neither supported nor supervised, thereby affecting the effectiveness of the schooling system. It may be fair to say that the learning

crisis today could, among other reasons, be attributed to this ambiguity. Equally, this could also be one of the factors that contribute to the lack of accountability of teachers.

Notes

1. During a presentation of this research to MHRD, the Secretary stated that the “government has spent a lot of funds on multi-grade and CCE training. Therefore, the teachers’ claim, that multi-grade related training is insufficient, is not correct. This report should highlight the funds that have been spent on training and how many teachers have attended multi-grade training...” We tried to access information on multi-grade training done in the nine states. With the exception of Tamil Nadu, where the ABL program is being implemented, and Karnataka, where NaliKali is being implemented, we did not find any data on “multi-grade” training. Equally, there is no robust Management Information System on the number of teacher trainings attended by teachers along with the topics covered. This remains a serious lacuna.
2. As specified by the RTE.